estate of his father, a prosperous upholsterer. Then, after several tours abroad in search of health, he had remarried (this time a woman of his own age and station, whom he loved prudently and sincerely until her death in 1765), and settled on an estate in Bedfordshire. Now he seemed to have found his true vocation, that of a quiet country gentleman, sincerely interested in the welfare of his cottagers, but so little concerned with State affairs that his only bid for public notice had been three papers in the *Philosophical Transactions* of the Royal Society, on some meteorological observations he had made, since watching a thermometer had been one of his favourite occupations.

The truth is that tin will cut cheese as well as steel, and so long as he was a small country squire Howard showed no particular pre-eminence among other small country squires, save that he was sober and devout—an Allworthy rather than a Western. But when the occasion arose he could bring into play those qualities which had been obscured by his previous sheltered life.

Courage, for instance, had little scope in a country village even in the eighteenth century, but only the most fearless would enter even a single dungeon in those days, knowing that the gaol-fever [1] was not only widely prevalent, but also acutely infectious and very often fatal. Howard braved this and other infections for seventeen years, and at last died from the effects of one of them, contracted in an attempt to succour a stricken girl on the distant shores of the Black Sea. And if his physical courage was outstanding, what is to be said of a moral courage that could constantly resist the instant possibility of a life of ease, and choose instead danger, unrest, and the constant company of wretchedness and despair? As he progressed along the narrow path he had chosen, the temptations that faced him did not lessen: his growing fame led kings and princes all over Europe to flatter him and seek his company. Howard's method was the same with all: if he felt their interest could further his work he agreed to see them, and then told them all the most unpalatable facts he knew about their prison administration. Otherwise he sent a message to say he was too busy.

His industry, indeed, was untiring. Another, and a conscientious man, might have thought his work well done when

[1] The continued practice of placing herbs before the judge at the Old Bailey is a reminder of the former prevalence of gaol fever at Newgate.

he had once inspected every English gaol and published his investigations. Not so Howard. Before writing his book he visited every English prison two or three times, then toured Europe twice "conjecturing that something useful to my purpose might be collected abroad." And this is the manner in which he prepared his work for the Press: "so indefatigable was he in his attention to the business that during a very severe winter he was always called up by two in the morning, though he did not retire to rest until ten, and sometimes half after ten, at night. His reason for his early rising was that he found the morning the stillest part of the day, and that in which he was least disturbed in his work of revising the sheets as they came from the Press."

The State of the Prisons appeared in 1777, and Howard might then reasonably have considered his task accomplished. Had he done so, his social influence might have been commensurate with that of Henry Feilding the novelist who had, in 1751, produced *An Enquiry into the Increase of Robbers*, dealing with the same problem, but now almost forgotten.

Instead Howard devoted the remainder of his life to the cause he had taken up, and thus those who were not convinced by the argument of his book could hardly fail to be impressed by the example of his life. A second and third edition of *The State of the Prisons* followed in 1780 and 1784, each the result of further tours of inspection, and about this time the following note appears in one of Howard's memorandum books:

AN ACCOUNT OF THE NUMBER OF MILES TRAVELLED ON THE REFORM OF PRISONS

JOURNEYS	MILES
In Great Britain and Ireland, 1773–6	10,318
First Foreign Journey, 1775	1,400
Second Ditto, 1776	1,700
Third Ditto, 1778	4,636
In Great Britain and Ireland, 1779	6,490
Fourth Foreign Journey, 1781	4,465
In Great Britain and Ireland, 1782	8,165
Fifth Foreign Journey, 1783	3,304
To Ireland	715
To Worcester	238
To Hertford, Chelmsford, and Warrington	602
TOTAL	42,033

To God alone be all praise! I do not regret the loss of many conveniences of life, but bless God who inclined my mind to such a scheme.